

The law requires you to use your headlights from one-half hour after the sun sets to one-half hour before the sun rises, when visibility is less than 1,000 feet (300 m) and when you use your windshield wipers to clear rain, snow or sleet. Turn your headlights on at dawn, dusk and in fog. Even when headlights do not help you see in low-light periods, they make it easier for other drivers and pedestrians to see your vehicle. Do not use parking lights or daytime running lights as a replacement. Headlights do a better job. If an oncoming driver flashes headlights at you during a period of low visibility, it means your vehicle was difficult to see and you should turn on your headlights.

Be considerate when you use your high beams. Your headlights must be on low beam when you are within 500 feet (150 m) of an oncoming vehicle or within 200 feet (60 m) of a vehicle ahead of you, even if the vehicle ahead is in a different lane. You should also dim your lights for pedestrians who approach you. Any fog or driving lights your vehicle has must be arranged, adjusted or operated to avoid dangerous glare to other drivers.

If an approaching driver does not dim the headlights, flash your headlights to high beam for a second, then return to low beam. To help avoid the glare of approaching high beams, move your eyes to the right. Use the road edge as a guide until the approaching vehicle passes by.

To reduce glare from the lights of following vehicles, switch your inside rear view mirror to the "night" position.

Light from inside your vehicle or from street lights makes it harder for you to see the road ahead. Keep the interior roof light off and dim the dashboard lights. Adjust your visors to reduce glare from lights from above.

A dirty windshield increases glare from approaching headlights. Make sure your lights and windshield glass are clean for night driving.

DRIVING IN RAIN, FOG OR SNOW

A bit of rain, snow or ice makes roads slippery. Wet leaves can be slippery and hazardous.

Reduced speed and increased following distance improve your safety under these conditions (see Chapter 8). Take additional care on curves, turns and expressway ramps.

In heavy rain, your tires can begin to ride on the water that is on top of the road pavement. This is called "hydroplaning" and can cause complete loss of traction and control of steering. Hydroplaning normally occurs at higher speeds, but it also can occur if your tires are tread worn or not inflated properly. When there is heavy rain, it always makes sense to drive more slowly. If your vehicle begins to lose traction, decrease your speed even more. Good tires with deep tread help to prevent hydroplaning.

Rain, fog or snow make it harder to see through your windshield, and difficult for other drivers to see you. New York State law requires you to turn on your headlights when the weather conditions require the use of windshield wipers to clear rain, snow, sleet or fog. "Daytime running lights" do not qualify as headlights.

Headlights on high beams reflect rain, fog and snow as it falls. This makes it even harder for you to see. For better visibility during these weather conditions, keep your headlights on low beam. Reduce your speed. Signal your turns further ahead of time to give other drivers and roadway users more warning. Brake early when you decrease speed behind another vehicle or come to an intersection stop.

Some vehicles have front fog lights or front and back fog lights, for use when heavy fog or similar hazardous weather conditions restrict visibility. In New York State, all fog lights must be correctly installed and of a type approved by the Commissioner of DMV. Front fog lights can be amber or white in color. Back fog lights must be red and can be larger than the normal back lights - they will give advance warning of the presence of your vehicle to the drivers behind you. When visibility improves, you can switch off your fog lights to reduce the glare that can bother other drivers.

HOW TO DRIVE IN WINTER

Winter is the most difficult season in which